

## Partners at home

Far fewer employers offer paid leave to partners than paid maternity leave to new moms. According to the Institute for Women's Policy Research, only 50 percent of 2006's 100 most family-friendly companies offered paid parental leave. Of them 35 percent paid for one to two weeks leave, and no companies paid for more than six weeks of parental leave. Partners who want to be home for a newborn's earliest days may be able to use paid vacation or sick leave, or they can take FMLA leave.

## Going back to work

Before returning to work, consider:

- Will life as a working mom be easier if you switch to a flexible working arrangement, such as a job share or part-time work? Give your employer ample time to consider any request.
- If you're breastfeeding, will your employer provide a private, clean, and safe room for you to express and store breast milk?
- You're entitled to time off (it may be unpaid) for family emergencies.
- You may be eligible for working and child tax credits, which can help with child-care costs..

## Breastfeeding

Most states (47 of them) have laws that protect a mother's basic right to breastfeed her child. But women still experience negative reactions when they nurse in public. Nearly half of the states (21 of them) have laws that protect women's rights related to lactation and employment. Being able to pump at work prolongs the amount of time that you can breastfeed your baby, so these protections are important to breastfeeding moms.

According to La Leche league, during an 8-hour workday, many moms find time to pump three times a day: during morning, lunch, and afternoon breaks. Since time is a premium at work, many moms get by with double-pumping with electric pumps, which should supply enough milk for the following day. La Leche League recommends that working moms should breastfeed their babies when they are at home mornings, evenings, and weekends.

## Child care

If you will be returning to work, you will likely need child care for your baby. It is wise to look into your child care options while you are still pregnant, because it may take time to make a decision, and some programs may have long waiting lists. Contact a local child-care resource and referral center for recommendations.

Some employers offer flexible spending accounts to employees that reduce salary by a set amount to pay for tax-preferred expenditures like day care. You won't pay taxes on the set-aside funds. Check with your human resources department to see if a flexible spending account is available to you.

### PAID LEAVE: THE FACTS

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